Sikri to meet Salim. The prince, unable to bear her questioning gaze, hurriedly sailed away on the Yamuna back to Ajmer while Hamida Banu, heartbroken, returned to the city. Akbar had also sent instructions to his officers at Agra to guard the city against the prince and its massive gates had been slammed shut, its stone walls bristling with heavily armed soldiers.

Salim now made the decision to proceed to Allahabad where ‘he seized people’s fiefs, took possession of the Bihar treasury…and gave himself the title of emperor’. For the next four years, from 1600–1604, Salim set himself up almost as an independent ruler in Allahabad with a parallel court, having the khutba read in his name, appointing officers, distributing titles, and giving himself the appellation ‘Shah’. The city that Salim had chosen as his refuge was no ordinary one. Built at the Triveni Sangam, the holy confluence of the Ganga, Yamuna, and Saraswati, this was a most sacred place. It was the favoured destination of those who were at the opposite end of the spectrum from the jewelled and mannered officers of Salim’s court—the sadhus and yogis of Hindustan.

At first, Akbar did not appear unduly perturbed by this denouement, preferring to send the officer and painter Muhammad Sharif to reason with the prince. But Muhammad Sharif, the son of the painter Abd al-Samad, had grown up with Salim in Lahore. The two young boys had haunted Akbar’s ateliers, equally enchanted by the magic of the crystal colours and the exquisite and supple forms bleeding life into the folios. In Allahabad, therefore, Salim quickly convinced Muhammad Sharif to join his own fledgling court. For Salim, this would have been a further act of conscious provocation and rebellion as Muhammad Sharif was no ordinary artist and officer. He was the son of the founder of Akbar’s taswir khana—one of the two men to have trained all the future artists of Hindustan. With his impeccable Persian lineage, and his father’s association with Humayun, Muhammad Sharif added heft to Salim’s claim to Timurid rule.

♦

A digression would be in order here to deepen our understanding of Salim, the man who would eventually succeed Akbar as the Padshah Jahangir. Overshadowed by Akbar, he has come across as a rather unprepossessing figure and the only area in which he rivalled and even outdid his father was, as we have noted briefly, in the patronizing of artists and creation of art. In his entourage Salim already had a number of artists including the Persian